

Technical Writing

ENGL 2210 – Section 502

Department of English & Communication

Summer 2026

Instructor Information

Instructor: Prof. Sandra L. Merritt

Email: slmerritt@wcu.edu

Office Location: Farrow Hall 318

Office Hours: TTh 9:00am – 11:30am or by appointment

Preferred Method of Contact: slmerritt@wcu.edu or Campus LMS Inbox

When emailing, please include your course section number or class meeting time. My goal is to respond to all student communications within 24–48 hours on weekdays.

Teaching Assistant(s)

Yusuf Abara | Writing Lab TA | yabara@wcu.edu

Course Details

Meeting Days/Times/Locations

Start Date	End Date	Location	Meeting Day	Start Time	End Time
05/27/2026	09/15/2026	FARR 0210	TTh	11:00 AM	12:15 PM

Credit Hours: 3.00

Course Description

Development of practical writing skills for professional and technical contexts. Students will produce a variety of workplace documents including memos, reports, proposals, instructions, and digital communications. Emphasis on audience analysis, document design, and revision strategies.

Required Texts and Materials

Textbook: Technical Communication

ISBN: 9781319245573

Authors: Markel, Mike / Selber, Stuart A.

Publisher: Bedford/St. Martin's

Edition: 13th

Additional Required Materials

- Microsoft Word (required)
- Adobe Acrobat Reader (free)
- Access to WCU Writing Center (free)

Course Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. CLO 1: Analyze audience, purpose, and context to produce appropriate technical documents
2. CLO 2: Apply document design principles including visual hierarchy, white space, and typography
3. CLO 3: Draft, revise, and edit professional workplace documents across multiple genres
4. CLO 4: Integrate graphics, tables, and visuals effectively into written documents
5. CLO 5: Collaborate with peers through structured review and feedback processes
6. CLO 6: Evaluate the ethical and cultural dimensions of professional communication

Grading Policies & Grading Scale

Grade Breakdown

Activity	Weight	Details
Participation & Peer Review	10%	In-class workshops, peer feedback sessions, attendance
Short Writing Exercises	10%	Weekly low-stakes writing tasks; lowest 2 dropped
Document Project 1 – Memo & Email Set	10%	Professional memo + follow-up email; due June 19
Document Project 2 – Instructions Manual	15%	Step-by-step technical instructions; due July 10
Midterm Exam 1	15%	Covers genres, design, and audience analysis; June 25, 2026
Document Project 3 – Formal Report	15%	Research-based formal report; due August 7
Midterm Exam 2	10%	Covers reports, proposals, ethics; July 23, 2026
Final Portfolio & Exam	15%	Revised portfolio + written exam; September 12, 2026
Total	100%	

Grading Scale

A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	F
100–93	92–90	89–87	86–83	82–80	79–77	76–73	72–70	69–67	66–63	62–60	59–00

NOTE: Final grades are recorded as posted. No grade changes will be made after final grades are submitted.

Late Work Policy

- Late work is penalized 10% per day of delay.
- Assignments more than 5 days late will not be accepted.
- Lab/in-class work cannot be made up without a documented, university-approved excuse.

Important Exam Dates

Assessment	Date / Details
Midterm Exam 1	Covers genres, design, and audience analysis; June 25, 2026
Midterm Exam 2	Covers reports, proposals, ethics; July 23, 2026
Final Portfolio & Exam	Revised portfolio + written exam; September 12, 2026

Course Schedule

Note: This schedule is subject to change. Any modifications will be announced via the LMS and/or email.

Week / Dates	Topic(s)	Assignments / Notes
Week 1 (May 27–29)	Intro to Technical Writing; Workplace Communication	Exercise 1 due
Week 2 (Jun 2–5)	Audience & Purpose; Memo Writing	Exercise 2 due
Week 3 (Jun 9–12)	Email Etiquette; Editing for Clarity	Exercise 3 due
Week 4 (Jun 16–19)	Document Design Principles	Doc Project 1 due Jun 19
Week 5 (Jun 23–26)	EXAM 1 – Jun 25 Instructions & Procedures	Exercise 4 due
Week 6 (Jun 30–Jul 3)	Visuals & Graphics in Documents	Exercise 5 due
Week 7 (Jul 7–10)	Technical Descriptions & Definitions	Doc Project 2 due Jul 10
Week 8 (Jul 14–17)	Research Methods for Technical Writers	Exercise 6 due
Week 9 (Jul 21–24)	EXAM 2 – Jul 23 Proposal Writing	Exercise 7 due
Week 10 (Jul 28–31)	Formal Report Structure	Exercise 8 due
Week 11 (Aug 4–7)	Data Presentation & Argumentation	Doc Project 3 due Aug 7
Week 12 (Aug 11–14)	Intercultural Communication	Exercise 9 due

Week / Dates	Topic(s)	Assignments / Notes
Week 13 (Aug 18–21)	Presentations & Oral Delivery	Presentation drafts due
Week 14 (Aug 25–28)	Portfolio Workshop & Peer Review	Portfolio drafts due
Week 15 (Sep 2–5)	Final Review	Final Portfolio submission Sep 5
Final Exam	September 12, 2026 11:00 AM – 1:00 PM	Comprehensive Written Exam

Course Policies

- All major projects must be submitted as .docx files via the LMS by 11:59 PM on the due date.
- Late submissions lose 10% per day; no submissions accepted after 5 days past due date.
- Generative AI may be used for brainstorming ONLY; all final submitted text must be your own writing.
- Plagiarism, including uncited AI-generated text, will result in a zero and an academic integrity report.
- Attendance is essential; more than 4 absences may result in a grade penalty.
- Peer review participation is mandatory; missing peer review sessions counts as an absence.

Attendance Policy

Regular attendance is essential to success in this course. Students are expected to attend all scheduled class sessions and arrive on time. Attendance will be recorded each session.

Free Absences: Students are permitted two (2) free lecture absences and one (1) free lab absence per semester without penalty or documentation. Use these wisely.

Religious Observances: Notify the instructor in writing within the first two weeks of the semester. Arrangements for make-up work must be made in advance.

University Events: Provide official documentation from your university sponsor. Contact the instructor well in advance.

Exam Day Absences: Medical absences on exam days require documentation from a physician or the University Health Center and will be handled on a case-by-case basis.

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to maintain the highest standards of academic honesty. All submitted work must represent the student's own effort. Violations of the Academic Integrity Policy, including plagiarism, cheating, or unauthorized use of AI-generated content, will be referred to the Office of Academic Affairs and may result in a failing grade for the assignment or the course.

Generative AI Policy

The use of generative AI tools (including but not limited to ChatGPT, Google Gemini, Copilot, and DALL-E) is governed by the policy stated in the grading section above. Any violations will be treated as academic dishonesty. Students are encouraged to maintain time-stamped drafts and notes as evidence of independent work.

Disability Accommodations & Title IX

Disability Accommodations

Students who require academic accommodations must register with the Disability Resource Center (DRC) at drc.wcu.edu or by calling 828-227-2716. Once registered, students must submit an accommodation letter to the instructor at least one week before accommodations are needed. Accommodations are not retroactive.

Sexual Harassment & Title IX

All forms of sexual harassment, including sexual assault and dating violence, violate WCU policy and may violate federal law. Students may report concerns to the Title IX Coordinator at titleix@wcu.edu or 828-227-7021. Faculty are mandatory reporters.

Student Support Services

- Academic Success Center – Free tutoring and academic coaching: asc.wcu.edu
- Writing & Learning Commons – Writing support for all disciplines: writingcenter.wcu.edu
- Counseling & Psychological Services (CAPS) – Mental health support: 828-227-7469
- University Health Services – Medical and wellness support: 828-227-7640
- Dean of Students Office – Emergency support and student advocacy: 828-227-7234

Note: This syllabus is subject to change. The instructor reserves the right to modify the course schedule, assignments, and policies. Changes will be announced promptly via the LMS.